

death-in-life/life-in-death contemporary middle-class Indian existence, it is in these glancing moments of human connection that the possibility of redemption lies, like rummaging through garbage for the promise of a rose.

A putrid odour of death, however, pervades the novel, while a caustic irony, now entirely identifiable as Chatterjee's, suggests slyly that if there is any suitable, desirable "way to go", it is not to be found in the feeble attempts made by the various protagonists of his novel still fighting to put down their "last burden", to rid themselves of their unbearable heavinesses of being. Jamun, with unusual sexual predilections, shuffles through a life less ordinary in a derelict old house with a decrepit aged father for company and a limited array of peculiar friends, neighbours and household help to keep him alternately entertained and repulsed. Their next-of-kin, elder brother/son Burfi, has distanced himself from this warped patrilineage and lives elsewhere with his foreigner-spouse Joyce and two children. Jamun pursues an intriguing relationship with his former love, Kasturi, and her (his?) daughter Mithi—in whom he spies remnants of his father Shyamanand.

Jamun and (the married) Kasturi share, in fact, an entrancingly-bohemian arrangement in which Jamun ferries Mithi to school occasionally and organises her poolside birthday party at a hotel, during which Kasturi occupies a distant-but-friendly seat at the next table and participates distractedly in the proceedings. Kasturi is a TV serial magnate much in the likeness of an Ekta Kapoor, whose TRP-zooming show *Cheers Zindagi* is watched by the young, aged and ageless with unfathomable (but life-imitating) zeal. Jamun strides her show like a colossus in the avatar of a nostril-flaring apology for manhood with the unlikely appellation of Ashwamedha Ponytail: this may well be Chatterjee's coup de grace, for it is a caricature too unfortunate to be amusing, a character that is the repository of all Kasturi's bitterness against the man she once loved, embodying the calcified remains of the man he was. And the real tragedy of *Way to Go* is that it chronicles the lives not of those who are desultorily seeking ways out of the mess of existence but of those who, Sisyphus-like, keep coming back for more.

Shyamanand disappears into thin air. A neighbour, Naina Kapur, starves herself into rarefied death. Others contemplate and conspire on endings. What is most memorable about *Way to Go*, however, is that the primrose path is paved with a continually chiselled linguistic power that is at once elegant and knife-edge brittle. Chatterjee's searing pen stokes an everlasting bonfire: even as the embers die the ashes refuse to settle, producing an unsettling and pungent rumination on life, death and (im)possible ways out of both. ■

TOP 10

A monthly list of national bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG

FICTION

1. *2 States: The Story of My Marriage*
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa
2. *The Lost Symbol*
Dan Brown, Bantam Press
3. *Now that You're Rich... Let's Fall in Love*
Durjoy Datta and Maanvi Ahuja, Srishti
4. *Pirate Latitudes*
Michael Crichton, Harper
5. *Ford County*
John Grisham, Arrow

NON-FICTION

1. *Discover the Diamond in You*
Arindam Chaudhuri, Vikas
2. *The Difficulty of Being Good: On the Subtle Art of Dharma*
Gurcharan Das, Penguin
3. *Superfreakonomics*
Steven D. Levitt and Stephen J. Dubner, Penguin
4. *Simply Fly: A Deccan Odyssey*
Captain Gopinath, Collins
5. *Nine Lives: In Search of the Sacred in Modern India*
William Dalrymple, Bloomsbury

OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

FICTION

6. *Devil in Pinstripes*
Ravi Subramanian, Rupa
7. *Five Point Someone*
Chetan Bhagat, Rupa
9. *Karl, Aaj Aur Kal*
Cyrus Broacha, Random House

NON-FICTION

6. *The Professional*
Subroto Bagchi, Penguin
9. *Victoria & Abdul*
Shrabani Basu, Rupa
10. *Don't Lose Your Mind, Lose Your Weight*
Rujuta Diwekar, Random House

Participating bookshops: Delhi: Om Book Shop, Teksons, Land Mark, Crossword; Mumbai: Oxford, Shah Book Stall, Modern Book Shop; Bangalore: Gangarams, Land Mark; Hyderabad: Walden Book Link, The Book Point; Kolkata: Oxford Books, Modern Book Depot, Family Book Shop; Chennai: Land Mark

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